

Word Choice & Standard Usage

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Choose words and expressions that are grammatically correct, precise in meaning, and appropriate for standard written English.

2. What this skill means

Editing questions often place two words or expressions close together because they sound similar or are common in speech. Your job is not to choose what sounds familiar. Check the word's grammatical job, its meaning in the sentence, and whether the expression is standard in formal writing.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not confuse everyday speech with standard written usage. A phrase can be common in conversation and still be wrong for an editing question. Also separate meaning from spelling: affect/effect, advice/advise, accept/except, and their/there/they're do different jobs.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask you to choose the correct word, replace an informal expression, or select the revision that is most appropriate for a formal notice, report, or workplace message.

5. Repeatable method

- Identify the job of the missing or underlined word.
- State the intended meaning in simple words.
- Test the choices one at a time in the sentence.
- Reject choices that change the meaning or use the wrong grammatical form.
- Reread the complete sentence for standard, natural written English.

6. Worked example

The new reminder may affect how many patients arrive on time. The clinic will measure the effect after eight weeks.

Question: Why are affect and effect different here?

Reasoning: In the first sentence, the word names an action, so the verb affect is needed. In the second, the word names a result, so the noun effect is needed.

Best answer: Use affect for the action and effect for the result in these sentences.

7. Common traps

- Choosing a word because it sounds similar to the correct one.
- Keeping conversational forms such as should of or gotta in formal writing.
- Changing a sentence to a different meaning while fixing one word.

8. Diagnostic help

- If you keep missing confused words, label each choice as noun, verb, adjective, or other job before deciding.
- If an informal phrase looks tempting, ask how you would write it in a school or workplace report.
- If two choices seem possible, substitute each one and explain the exact meaning it creates.

Why this matters in ER: Precise word choice helps your ER analysis say exactly what a source claims. Standard usage also keeps grammar errors from distracting the reader.

9. Quick check

The supervisor gave the team useful advice and advised them to test the new form for one week.

Which word is the noun, and which is the verb?

Check yourself: Advice is the noun; advised is the verb.